Body Language Basics

Why It Matters

Reason	Detail
First impressions	We judge a stranger's character from body language.
No words needed	We use it to communicate when we can't speak.
Hiring	Employers and interviewers watch it closely.

Facial Expressions

Expression	Meaning
Avoiding eye contact	Shy, worried, or lying
A blank face	Hiding feelings, or no emotion
Direct eye contact	Confidence
Eyes looking into the distance	Daydreaming, not focused
Pressed lips (tight-lipped)	Annoyed or angry
Raised eyebrows	Doubtful or surprised
Smiling	Friendly
A fake smile (mouth only)	Being polite, not really happy

Posture and Stance

Posture	Meaning
Standing tall, shoulders back	Confident and in control
Slouching in the chair	Tired, bored, or unsure
Sitting on the edge of the seat	Keen and interested, or nervous
Leaning forward	Listening closely
Turning the body away	Wanting to end the conversation

Hand Gestures

Gesture	Meaning
Hands behind the back, shoulders back	Confident
Arms crossed	Defensive or insecure (sometimes angry)
Open palms, facing up	Honest and open
Both palms forward	Showing submission, or "stop"
Pointing with the index finger	Aggressive or accusing
Scratching the head	Confused
Shrugging shoulders	"I don't know", or unsure

Gesture	Meaning
Stroking the chin	Thinking deeply

Nervous Habits

Habit	Meaning
Biting the nails	Nervous
Blushing	Embarrassed
Covering an open mouth	Scared or shocked
Rubbing the eyes	Tired, or not believing something
Playing with a pen or phone	Bored, or anxious

Personal Space

Distance	Meaning
Standing under 45 cm away	Intimate — only for close friends or family
Standing 45–120 cm away	Personal space — normal for a friendly chat
Keeping 1.2–3 m apart	Social distance — for business and strangers
Stepping back as you move closer	Feeling uncomfortable or pressured
Standing shoulder to shoulder	Working together on the same task

Listening and Responding

Signal	Meaning
Nodding slowly	Agreement, or "yes"
Shaking the head	Saying "no"
Tilting the head to one side	Curious, or listening hard
Cupping a hand behind the ear	"I can't hear you"
Glancing at the clock or phone	Bored, or in a hurry

Meeting and Greeting

Action	Meaning
Firm handshake	Strong and confident
Limp handshake	Weak or uninterested
A two-handed handshake	Warm, but can feel too strong
A slight bow	A greeting in many countries
Offering a business card with both hands	Polite and respectful
Waiting for the senior person to sit first	Respect for age and rank
Checking your watch during a meeting	Rude — you look bored
Leaving your phone face-up on the table	Distracted, not fully present